The Vanishing of an Anti-AI Activist

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AI Executive Summary

Core Thesis The episode explores the escalating physical and social backlash against the artificial intelligence industry, centered on the disappearance of Sam Kirschner, founder of the radical activist group "Stop AI." It posits that as fears regarding job displacement, data centers, and existential risks from AGI (Artificial General Intelligence) intensify, the anti-AI movement is shifting from peaceful protest to volatile civil disobedience and targeted violence, creating a new era of security threats for tech executives and infrastructure.

Key Arguments & Data * The Evolution of Anti-AI Tactics: The movement has transitioned from peaceful demonstrations (e.g., PAWS AI) to high-profile, disruptive stunts designed for media exposure, such as chaining activists to OpenAI's headquarters and serving Sam Altman with a subpoena during a live public appearance. * **Rising Trend of Targeted Violence:** The episode cites specific instances of escalating physical threats, including: * A shooting at the home of an Indianapolis councilman following his support for local data centers. * An attempted firebombing of Sam Altman's residence by a 20-year-old student in San Francisco. * **Radicalization via Existential Dread:** The "existential risk" narrative (the idea that AI could lead to human extinction) acts as a primary driver for radicalization, pushing individuals toward more extreme, potentially violent, forms of "necessity defense." * **Internal Fragmentation of Activism:** There is an intensifying debate within activist circles between focusing on "kitchen table issues" (job losses, economic impact) and "existential threats" (AGI/superintelligence), leading to the splintering of groups and more uncompromising leadership. * **Industry Security Response:** In response to rising threats, major AI companies are increasing security budgets, hiring armed guards, and advising employees to avoid wearing company logos in public to prevent being targeted. * **Shifting Public Sentiment:** While once considered fringe, anti-AI sentiments are entering the mainstream; recent polls indicate declining enthusiasm for AI among Americans due to concerns over affordability and employment.

Actionable Takeaways * For Tech Organizations & Executives: Implement heightened personal security protocols and "low-profile" communication strategies for employees in high-visibility roles to mitigate the risk of targeted physical attacks. * **For Policy Makers & Regulators:** Develop frameworks to address the social and economic anxieties (such as data center placement and job displacement) that serve as the foundational catalysts for extremist radicalization. * **For Investors/Strategic Analysts:** Monitor "social license to operate" risks; the increasing volatility of anti-AI activism may lead to greater regulatory friction, increased operational costs due to security needs, and delays in infrastructure deployment (e.g., data centers).

Full Transcript

On a Friday morning in November of 2025, a 911 dispatcher in San Francisco gets a tip about a potentially violent attack. The dispatcher immediately relays the information to local police.

And they said that this is open AI. The person was coming here. They were making threats to kill people here. The dispatcher says that a man may be heading towards open AI's headquarters and that he's potentially armed. Police officers rush to open AI. Can we get some details about this? We're kind of going in live here. Yeah, copy. The cat is our ex-reference. The man the police are looking for is named Sam Kirschner. He's a founder of an anti-AI activist group called Stop AI. He's a white male, has some facial hair. Kirschner's photo is sent around to open AI employees, and the company locks down its campus. Police officers search the area but can't find Kirschner. Sam Kirschner went missing that day. The same day that open AI went on lockdown. It's very unusual for a prominent activist just to go missing. Yeah.

and no one finds them. Before he went missing, Kirchner had become more vocal in his hatred for AI companies. It became so alarming that his own friends in the Stop AI protest group called the police on him. Our colleague, Zusha Ellenson, covers extremism. Having covered activist movements, having covered law enforcement, having covered violence, I know that activist groups do not call the cops unless they think something is very wrong. Zush has been looking into Kirschner's disappearance for months. I think it's important to look at people like Sam because depending on how the future unfolds with AI, we could see a lot of men in his same situation. And so I was interested to find out what had driven him to this movement to fight AI and then what had pushed him over the edge. An open AI spokesman said that robust debate over AI makes their products better. But violent rhetoric and actions, quote, put people at risk and make it harder to have the conversation this moment needs. Today, we go inside Stop AI to learn how their founder's disappearance has shaken the movement and how the AI backlash has tech executives and employees fearing for their lives. Welcome to the Journal, our show about money, business, and power. I'm

Jessica Mendoza. It's Friday, July 31st. Coming up on the show, the AI backlash takes a dark turn. What is this group?

that Kirchner founded, Stop AI. So the Bay Area is ground zero for the AI industry, right? You have open AI, you have anthropic. At the same time that these AI companies are drawing people who want to get jobs there, who want to get into the AI industry, the Bay Area is also drawing people who are opposed to this technology who worry about how it's going to impact society. The activists joining this anti-AI movement are concerned about job losses, data centers, and even the robot apocalypse. And Sam Kirschner was one of those people. And Stop AI was really on the most extreme end of these groups. Zusha talked to all sorts of anti-AI activists to report the story. One of the first people he interviewed was a Stop AI member called Yako. I'm Yako.

That's what I prefer to go by anyway. The government knows me as Matthew Hall. I was a restaurant manager here in San Francisco for a decade before this. So, yeah, I kind of stumbled backwards into this experience. What restaurant can I ask? A bunch of different restaurants. I started at Chipotle. Then I kind of got tired of the corporate nature of it. And so I was at different mom and pop kind of restaurants. Yako told Zusha that what he first learned about AI, his main concern was about how much it was going to take over our lives. Like, are we going to be asking AI what should I eat for breakfast in the morning? What should I be studying in school? What job should I pursue? Who should I date? Should I date this person or that person? Who do I really love? And it's like even in a best case scenario where AI doesn't become uncontrollable, we're essentially giving away our free will. And that to me just feels like dystopian. Yako had always been political, but he felt like he hadn't really found his people yet. Then in 2024, Yako ran into some activists. These folks talked with urgency, and Yako liked that about them. They'd hand out flyers and wear bright red t-shirts with the words stop AI written in white text, like a stop sign. He decided to go to one of their meetings. And that's where he met Sam Kirschner. And my first impressions of him was that, like, he really understood what he was talking about. All right, so thank you everyone for coming to this meeting for the purpose of stopping AI.

Kirchner would hold stop-AI meetings in bars across the Bay Area. Though sometimes, because a lot of the people showing up were underage, they'd hold them at Tender Greens, the salad restaurant. The group also posted their meetings on YouTube. At meetings, Kirchner would hold court, wearing a red stop-AI t-shirt, usually a baseball cap too. He'd stare out into the audience with these dark, unflinching eyes and talk about the dangers of artificial general intelligence. Artificial general intelligence or AGI, which can lead to artificial superintelligence or ASI. Kirschner warned that there could come a point where the technology would get so advanced that it would see humans as simply obstacles and that AI could then systematically wipe us out, like a real-life terminator. And there's just...

no way you can prove that that's smarter than human system will stay safe forever. So that's why we need to permanently ban it because an ant can't control a human, right? Like if we're the ants and the superintelligence is the humans in that analogy, there's nothing an ant can do to stop a human from doing whatever they want. Kushner would play early clips of tech leaders seeming to make his point for him, including ones of open AI CEO Sam Altman. This one's crazy. You know, I think AI will probably like most likely sort of lead to the end of the world but in the meantime There will be great companies created with serious machine learning It's interesting Zushia that Kirchner was kind of using Sam Altman's own words Against him like as a way to recruit people into the movement. Yeah, and a lot of the people getting into this movement talked about that messaging as something that radicalized them, which is very interesting, right? So it's the messaging coming from the AI industry itself that's really radicalizing people. At the end of stop AI meetings, Kirschner would make a call to action. This is not just a talk for you to come learn about how we could all die and then go home and scroll on TikTok. You need to do something. You cannot just take in this information and do nothing. You have to do something. People that you love are going to die.

people that I love are going to die. I'm begging you please, like, help. We need everyone to get involved now. How did Sam get to that place as an activist? So Sam grew up in the Seattle area. He came from an engineering background and he loved coming up with ideas and tinkering. And so, you know, in his 20s, he came up with this idea to create a bicycle that you

pedal with your arms and your legs. And the idea was that it could go faster than a normal bicycle while also giving you an upper body workout. And his dad, an engineer, helped him file this patent. And it's actually pending right now. As an engineer, Kirschner was already concerned about AI's impact on his own career prospects. And he started reading books that warned about an impending doomsday.

And they make a deep impression on him, and he's really worried that AI would sort of stamp out that spark of human ingenuity. Kirchner grew so worried that he went out into the streets by himself. In Seattle, he started staging solo protests outside tech companies. In one of them, he carried a sign that said, quote, there is no one there but Sam, standing outside of Google, outside of Microsoft, outside of different places. talking about how basically AI is going to take away the meaning from human existence. The solo protests didn't do much, so Kirschner started looking around for other like-minded activists. That's when he found a woman named Holly Elmore. It's really very normal for species to go extinct. Most species that have ever existed are extinct today. Holly has a PhD in evolutionary biology from Harvard.

And she founded an anti-AI group called PAWS AI US. She linked up with Kirschner back in February of 2024 when he helped out with the protest. Holly had been leading small groups in peaceful demonstrations in San Francisco. He was great. Honestly, he came down in his truck. He made signs that were nice. He was like very business-like about it. He slept in his truck. He didn't even bother anyone to stay on their couch. So that was the first time that I met him. At first, Kirschner was nothing but helpful to pause AI. But he quickly became convinced that the movement needed to get louder through more direct acts of civil disobedience. Kirschner and another member started pitching ideas that involved breaking the law, like chaining themselves to the doors of open AI.

But that was a line that Holly didn't want to cross. And I told them, like, we're not going to do illegal things in PAWS AI. And they kept pushing it. And so I kicked them out because of that. I just kind of matter, if actually was, like, get out, like, you got to do your own thing. Cast out, Kirschner and another activist decided to form their own group in the spring of 2024.

They called it Stop AI. Holly wasn't thrilled. It was very annoying because it's almost like they copied our name. It's like they leave and then they like create a constant source of confusion for everybody. Kirschner branded his group as more radical than Holley's, but still explicitly committed to non-violence. One of Stop AI's earliest recruits was Yaco. And they were like, we have a spot. We could use your help if that's something you'd like to do. And so I moved into this very small house.

that we were all sharing. Yako moved into a spot in an industrial area of Oakland that became known as the Barracks. Kirschner already lived there, along with two other guys who had joined the movement. The Barracks became the heart of Stop AI, the group's headquarters, and a home where the leaders lived full-time. Here's Zusha and Yako again. What was it like joining forces with the folks at Stop AI? Describe where you moved, what you guys were doing. It was... One room, including the kitchen and a bathroom. There was four of us and we slept in two bunk beds so we were literally right on top of each other. The only way to get any space from each other was to physically like leave the house. And basically they spend all their time together. They wake up, they work on their protest flyers, they do a little fundraising. A lot of times Sam would have something that he really was passionately working on, whether that was a press release or he was taking calls from people who were fighting data centers in their communities. Yako describes the barracks as something like a dysfunctional family. Still, it gave him purpose. It was like finally finding people who were putting their money where their mouth was and they weren't just paying lip service.

to their beliefs. They believed these things so much that they dropped everything in their lives. And they came out here and moved into a one room, I'm not going to say shack, but shack. And we're just focused on this and working on this 24-7 full time. Most of the activists in Stop AI weren't all that experienced, except for Wind Kaufman. I don't really have a visceral fear of extinction. Wind is in her late 60s. She'd been arrested for acts of nonviolent civil disobedience before. The guys in the barracks respected that. Wind is a longtime activist in the Bay Area. She's been involved in a lot of different causes, most recently the Palestinian cause, that sort of

thing. And she, I think, provided kind of a counterweight to these young, impatient men. I once told them that they should go to a non...

Violent communication workshop, because the way they conducted their meetings was just ridiculous. They always ended up yelling at each other and calling each other names. Wait, why would they yell at each other at the meeting? Because they disagreed about stuff, like bringing in other issues. A big point of debate for the group was messaging. Some members thought that stop AI would have an easier time recruiting if they focused on more kitchen table issues like mass layoffs and data centers. Sam's position was none of that matters if nobody's here. And so, and he is right. It's like if you're all about to die, then really having a job doesn't matter. Kirschner was stubborn. Once, when a group member suggested printing stop AI on purple shirts rather than red, Kirschner blew up at them. Wynn says she once suggested to Kirschner that he should get help from a therapist. I don't know that I ever remember him laughing.

Hmm, that's something like something maybe he'll like if somebody makes a joke, he'll go You know, but like really laughing. I don't think I ever remember him doing that By the time wind got involved with stop AI Kershner was focused on staging big acts of civil disobedience The goal was to get arrested in order to get a trial That way stop AI could challenge the dangers of AI in a courtroom They pulled off one of those big stunts in February of 2025. Kirchner and three stop AI activists wrap a chain around the front door of OpenAI's headquarters. They lock the chain with a master lock and sit down in front of it. You attend protesters gathered today outside the San Francisco headquarters of tech firm OpenAI concerned that their technology could cause, quote, human extinction. Your life is at stake. Sam was at the...

megaphone and saying, you know, we're asking people to join us in sitting down and blocking the doors. Everything we love is being put at risk by the global race to super intelligence. I looked at them and they're just four white guys. I'm like, you know, they could really use one more person and a woman. When takes a seat in front of the doors with the rest of the group. Within an hour, the police show up. But some of the stop AI members don't budge. Officers cut the chains from open AI's doors and arrest the

protesters. And this was really a big moment for them. They were going to get to have this big splash of publicity to explain why they were protesting. That's the whole point of civil disobedience. And so they're very excited. Now, Stop AI had a trial ahead of them. Here's Kirschner talking about their defense strategy on a podcast. When the trial comes, the planners do lead the necessity of defense. And basically say that the actions we took are necessary and just because we're trying to raise awareness that these companies are going to kill everyone and nor take all of our jobs. For the trial, Stop AI planned to collect evidence from one very important witness. They would try to get Sam Altman, the CEO of Open AI, into court to testify and they would talk about how the dangers of AI were so great that they had to be arrested for basically warning the public about them. Stop AI's attorneys had been trying to serve Sam Altman with a subpoena for months without success.

Finally, in November of 2025, they got their chance. Altman was scheduled to give a talk with another big San Francisco name, the coach of the Golden State Warriors, Steve Kerr. This is Sam Altman, and this is Coach Kerr. And I'm Annie. Altman's sitting on stage in a plush yellow chair. He's in sneakers, jeans, and a long sleeve t-shirt. And just as the conversation is about to start, The moderator gets interrupted. A man saunters onto the stage, waving a piece of paper in Altman's direction. Altman sits there, looking stunned and confused. He's just been served. What the heck? Check this out. Sam Altman getting served with a subpoena live during a speech? Video of the subpoena moment hits the internet. Just minutes into their talk, a man rushed onto the stage, paper in hand, and declared that he was serving Sam Altman with a subpoena. Now, Altman's been called as a witness at a trial that could literally become the first courtroom debate in history about whether artificial intelligence poses an extinction level threat. This video went super viral.

because it was the CEO of OpenAI, one of the most important companies in the country, looking very quizzically and surprised at this investigator handing him a Spina. And so that was really the high point for Stop AI in terms of exposure, right? It was really this stroke of luck that got them on the map. It was pretty exciting. It was definitely a pretty exciting moment. In the barracks, Yako says the activists were thrilled with the amount of

attention that their cause was finally receiving. But it wasn't exactly like we were popping champagne bottles. It was more like, OK, cool. We scored a win. And then it was just like, OK, so what are we going to do now? So how do we build on this? Over at PAWS AI, Holly Elmore had seen the video, too. And she was impressed with what Kirschner had pulled off. Cars on the table. I did not think that was going to work. And then he was actually succeeding. And he had like the major prize was there. And it's two weeks later that he just throws it all away. Like I, it still shocked me. What happened? Soon, Sam Kirschner would vanish. That's after the break. The high of the Altman subpoena didn't last long. Here's Matthew Hall, aka Yako. Things were going well on the surface. We were scoring some wins, but the tension in the group had been building for a long time.

I think some people in the group came to resent Sam. They really, really came to despise him. Sam Kirschner was growing increasingly harsh and uncompromising. Yeah, he was a jerk. He was stubborn. But he was a good man, and he was really just trying to help people the best way that he knew how. Unbeknownst to Yako, though... Kirchner was having serious doubts about his commitment to non-violence. Here's Zusha again. We spoke with one stop AI member who said that Sam would take him out of the barracks there. They would leave their phones in the barracks so no one could overhear them or I don't know what. And he would take him under the freeway and then he would kind of talk to him about whether violence might be necessary in this fight against AI.

Tensions came to a head at a meeting last year. It was a Sunday, November 16th. Stop AI leadership was in the barracks. Yaakov was there. And it ended up devolving into a pretty intense disagreement, argument over what I thought was a pretty petty difference. Wind was there too. She and Kirschner had been planning the group's next big stunt. We were preparing the message that we would put out once Sam and I did this thing. Kirchner and Wind were planning to scale the Golden Gate Bridge and hang an enormous stop AI banner from it. But the group was still arguing about what they would say along with the stunt. Kirchner wanted to say something about how human extinction is coming in the next one to three years. Another stop AI activist named Derek disagreed.

And Derek was like, no, we can't say that because next year then we're gonna have to say one to two years and then we're gonna have to say one to anyway. So he was like really argue and they were just arguing about this. I mean, they just screamed at each other. Kirschner was upset that the group wasn't following his lead on the messaging. He storms outside the barracks, takes a breather, then comes back in. And we all sit down and Sam sits down and says, well, I've decided that even though democracy is important, it's more important to get the correct message across. So I'm going to do this alone, and I'm going to use this message. And we're just all sitting there like, oh, seriously? Later that evening, Yako tried to calm Kirschner down. I cooked dinner for everybody. He didn't eat any. And then...

A couple minutes after we went to bed, he leaped out of the top bunk and started knocking furniture over and screaming. And I think he was thinking about how the group was being taken away from him, that he was so focused on this mission of trying to save people, of trying to protect innocent people. ran outside. It was raining. I remember it was raining. He ran outside with no shoes on and just screamed at the top of his lungs. Then Kirschner took his anger out on Yako. He told me, he said, you betrayed me. I don't trust you anymore. And I really, I didn't even get a chance to say much. Then he just started hitting me. He punched me like, I don't know, five or six times in the head.

And just saying stuff like you've doomed humanity. The next morning at the barracks, Yako says that Kirschner looked at him and said, the ship may have sailed on non-violence. Word got around to the rest of stop AI. They decide Kirschner can't be in the group anymore because of what he did to Yako. Then on Friday, November 21st, at 3.40 a.m., Kirschner posts on X, quote, I am no longer a part of STOP AI. That same day, Kirschner was supposed to show up for a hearing, one related to the trial over the arrest at Open AI. But he didn't show. And I went back to the house to check on him, and he was gone. The gate to the backyard was unlocked, a bike was missing, some camping gear was missing. He had left all of his electronic devices, his phone, his computer and all that stuff.

But he was gone. Yaku and I are kind of like, what the f*** is going on? The group decides to do something unthinkable. Here's Zusha. These

activist groups are often in an antagonistic relationship with law enforcement and would likely never want their help unless something was very serious. We were worried that he would get a gun and shoot up the employees. I mean, that was one scenario that could happen. You know, that's like the going postal scenario. One of the stop AI members called 911. This group that had been so intent on fighting open AI decided that they needed to warn them and save them from any potential violence. And they said that this is open AI. The person was coming here. They were making threats to kill people here. That's when open AI went on lockdown.

But nothing happened. The day ended without violence. The investigation is ongoing, and Sam Kirschner is still missing. What was it like for you to find him missing? My heart sank. Yako was one of the last stop AI members to see Sam Kirschner. And it was just... I don't know, I guess I just went into crisis mode. I was looking... all over the Bay Area. I was going out into the hills of Lafayette and Arenda. Day after day, Yako would load up with a bag of trail mix and water, and he'd searched the trails around the Bay Area, hoping to find Kirschner camped out somewhere. He even set up trail cameras. Nothing. Zusha has also been looking for Kirschner. He spoke to law enforcement. He poured through public records. He sent letters and even colleagues to Kirschner's family home.

And really we came up empty. I mean, he's a digital ghost at this point on the internet and no one has heard from him. Some people think he may have died in the wilderness. Other people were sort of worried that he's kind of laying in wait. Some people think he's back home with his family just laying low. Zusha did speak to Kirschner's father, but he declined to comment. So Sam Kirschner disappeared in November of 2025. What's been happening with the anti-AI movement since then? That's a really great question. We have seen a couple other cases, right, where these big ideas of the impending extinction of humanity have pushed young troubled people over the edge. This past April, an unknown assailant fired a gun into the home of an Indianapolis councilman who had voiced support for a local data center. Counsel Ron Gibson says he was home with his eight-year-old son when someone fired what appeared to be 13 shots at their front door.

A note reading no data centers was found at the Councilman's doorstep. Less than a week later, a Texas college student named Daniel Moreno-Gama was arrested. Investigators say the 20-year-old traveled to San Francisco to fire bomb the home of open A.I. CEO Sam Altman, then tried to burn down the corporate offices. Months before his arrest, Moreno-Gama had written in an internet chat about, quote, Luigi-ing some tech CEOs. And he's been charged with attempted murder, arson. He's pleaded not guilty. His lawyers say that he had an acute mental health episode that lent to this whole thing. But this seems to be a common theme in the AI safety movement. You have these young troubled people grappling with these really big ideas, and it does end disastrously sometimes. According to Wall Street Journal reporting, the volume of threats targeting AI companies and their employees is on the rise.

In response, some companies are increasing security budgets and hiring armed guards. These companies are, according to our sources, advising their employees not to wear company logos out in the public because they're afraid of people, how people might react. And that's a really big thing to see, a big shift. The anti-AI movement has grown fast, but the tip of the spear was stop AI and Sam Kirschner. What's interesting about that is that the beginning people would have looked at Stop AI and said, oh, who are these crazy people out on the street talking about the dangers of AI? But in the two years since they were founded, I think their ideas have become more embraced by the mainstream. Polls have shown that public enthusiasm for AI has been plummeting. Americans regularly express concern about the technology's effects on jobs and affordability, even as the technology becomes more ingrained in daily life.

By the way, News Corp, owner of the Wall Street Journal, has a content licensing partnership with OpenAI. And I think right now, the tech leaders are really grappling with this shift in the public's attitude towards them. And I think it's really crystallized with the backlash against AI. StopAI is still around. They have new leadership. And now they talk a lot more about job losses and data centers than human extinction. Earlier this summer, Stop AI had their trial over the open AI protests. Sam Altman didn't end up having to testify. Wind was found guilty and received a two-week sentence. She reports to jail in August. As for Yako, he's still in Stop AI, and he thinks

about Sam Kirschner a lot. I've thought about Sam probably every night, every day, since he's disappeared. And I pray that...

He's okay, if he's still out there. Who will hear a message to Sam if he were listening to this? What would you want to say? What I would want to tell Sam is that a lot has changed since he left. The national conversation around this issue has changed. And people want to hear his message out there. That's all for today, Friday, July 31st. Additional reporting in this episode by Lindsay Ellis and Tina Lee. This episode was produced by Sophie Codner and edited by Colin McNulty. The Journal is a co-production of Spotify and The Wall Street Journal. The show is made by Katherine Brewer, Evelyn Fajardo-Alvarez, Pia Kidkari, Max Green, Ryan Knudson, Matt Kwong, Laura Morris, Enrique Perez de la Rosa, Sarah Platt, Alan Rodriguez Espinoza, Heather Rogers, Pierre Singhi, Jiva Kavirma, Katherine Whalen, Tatiana Zamice, and me, Jessica Mendoza. Our engineers are Griffin Tanner, Nathan Singapok, and Peter Leonard. Our theme music is by So Wiley. Additional music this week from Peter Leonard, Bobby Lord, Emma Munger, Griffin Tanner, Nathan Singapok, So Wiley, and Blue Dot Sessions. Fact-checking this week by Nicole Pasolka. Thanks for listening. See you on Monday.